

Back on the beat



Al Mallette

The banner on the desk noted, "Welcome Back." A postscript could have said, "It's about time." It has been a long time. You've heard of the Lost Weekend. Well, I've lost a complete basketball-wrestling season. Personally, I'd rather have stayed around this old outpost. But circumstances didn't permit it.

What it meant were many more chores for Mark Fleisher, Don Bonnell, Dave Edick, Jerry Hogan, Joe Miranda, Bob Kravarik—not to mention Burt Blazar and Wayne Boucher—and all came through like the pros they are.

Since I last visited with you in this newspaper spot last Nov. 16 (and boy, it's good to be back), many things have happened

on the sports beat that I didn't have the opportunity to comment on—until now.

FOR INSTANCE, here are some belated congratulations to: Mike Johnston on his back-to-back Notre Dame championships in football and basketball. . . . Bob Costello (Horseheads football) on his coach of the year honor. . . . Ol' buddy Bill Limoncelli on his EFA basketball success. . . . Dave Messing and his classy EFA wrestlers, especially sectional kingpins Bob Hilfiger and Rich Foster. . . . Gridders of the year Brad Clark of Horseheads and Chris Crissy of Penn Yan.

Paul Brand for his excellent job as "designated chairman" for Bicentennial sports. . . . All the gang who teamed to make the Bicentennial Sports Reunion a success beyond expectations—350 expected, over 600 in attendance. . . . Patty Frost, Horseheads' fabulous freshman, on her athlete of the year honor. . . . Eric Childs of Sayre, the first Valley freshman wrestler ever to win a district title.

Elmira All-Sports for putting together what many consider to be the finest dais ever for its annual shindig — and a special thanks for a tribute I'll never forget. . . . Ol' pal Milt Paltrowitz and Gary Wydman for a grand Corning sports party.

The YMCA for its warm toast to the departing Rev. Sam Ha-

le. . . . Sandy (Swish) Swisher, pert Packer Hospital nurse, for being elected Tioga County Cancer Fund queen. . . . Jack Widman on his two New York State College Tournament swim championships. . . . Joel Robinson, Al (Phog) Allen and Tony Weaver on well-deserved Section 4 Hall of Fame induction.

THEN, TOO, WE lost several sports boosters through untimely deaths. And all will be missed.

LeRoy (Toy) Dawson was one of EFA's greatest friends—a long-time backer (time and money) of EFA's popular awards party.

Joseph (Joker) Herold is not only remembered as a charter member of Elmira's Arctic League, but he also played, managed and promoted baseball throughout the area and was one of the great horseshoe pitchers when that sport was big in the area.

John (Hot Dog Johnny) Scarborough not only packed a great hot dog bun at the M&M and the County Fair, but he was one of sports' best buddies.

Les Wolf enjoyed a long tenure of sports activity—mainly basketball and softball (he tossed 4 no-hitters) plus more than 20 years as a cage ref. His three sons—Terry, Gary and Mike—

were three-sports standouts at Edison, and daughter Margary (Sissey) is girls coach at Southside.

Charles (Buster) Chatham was a popular Elmira Pioneer shortstop in 1941 and teamed with Andy Cohen to give Elmira the oldest DP combination in Eastern League history. Buster was 38, Andy 36. Age had to mean something; the Pioneers won the Governor's Cup.

Cliff (Duner) Bradley enjoyed a winning pitching career in EFA, where he teamed with Lou Wood to form a stellar 1-2 punch. Duner later pitched for Rustic Gardens and standout Northern Pennsylvania teams.

Al Granger and John (Sailor) Devlin were two others who packed a lot of sports into busy careers.

Then there were the hospitalized ex-athletes and sports buffs who could have used a note of cheer—Bill Lloyd, Cliff West, Murph Solomon, Edgar (Eck) Schring, Liz Kinner Shoemaker, Frank Levine, Earl Foster, Jake Silverman and Ed McCarrell Jr. Send 'em cards, anyway. They're now all home recuperating and would love a note of cheer.

And a special thanks to those friends and readers for their welcomed and appreciated cards, letters and visits during my sidelining. No one ever again can tell me or my family that our town doesn't have a great big soft heart.